MBA-Equivalent Finance Curriculum

Mapped to Wharton / HBS / Columbia MBA finance tracks · Specific courses, verified instructors, strict prerequisite sequence

- Sequence is strict — each block builds on the previous. Do not skip ahead.
- MBA core at top schools (Wharton, HBS, Columbia, Booth) covers: Accounting → Corporate Finance → Macroeconomics & Markets → Valuation & Modeling → Investments → Derivatives & Risk → electives in Fixed Income, M&A;, Int'l Finance, Behavioral Finance, FinTech.
- This roadmap matches that sequence exactly, using the best available courses on your platforms (Coursera paid, Udemy via library card, Alison free).
- Estimated total: ~18–24 months part-time alongside McDaniel, at 3–5 hrs/week.

Sem 1 — Foundations — Accounting, Taxes & the Macro Environment

Wharton/HBS Year 1, Block 1 equivalent · Now → ~4 months · ~3 hrs/week

01 [MBA Core: Financial Accounting]

Introduction to Financial Accounting

UPenn / Wharton · Prof. Brian J. Bushee · Single course · 4.8★

Income statement, balance sheet, cash flow statement, GAAP accrual accounting. The required starting point — every downstream course assumes this.

Coursera · Single course

02 [MBA Core: Managerial Accounting]

Managerial Accounting: Cost Behaviors, Systems & Analysis

Univ. of Illinois · Prof. Gary Hecht · Single course

Cost behavior, budgeting, variance analysis, break-even, how managers use accounting data internally — distinct from financial reporting.

Coursera · Single course

03 [MBA Core: Taxation]

Federal Taxation I: Individuals, Employees & Sole Proprietors

Univ. of Illinois · Updated for 2025 tax law · Single course · 4.8★

Brackets, W-2 vs 1099, deductions, Form 1040 hands-on. Prerequisite to understanding after-tax returns in every investing course that follows.

Coursera · Single course

04 [MBA Core: Macroeconomics]

Economics of Money and Banking

Columbia University · Prof. Perry G. Mehrling · Single course · Top-rated

How money, credit, central banks and global financial markets actually work. Mehrling taught this at Columbia/Barnard since 1996. Far more rigorous and relevant than a generic macro MOOC.

Coursera · Single course

Sem 2 — Corporate Finance & Financial Modeling

Wharton/HBS Year 1, Block 2 equivalent · Months 4–8 · Prereq: Sem 1 complete

05 [MBA Core: Corporate Finance]

Corporate Finance Essentials

IESE Business School · Prof. Javier Estrada (PhD, Univ. of Illinois) · Single course · 4.8★ · 13 hrs

DCF, NPV, IRR, WACC, capital structure, cost of capital, dividend policy. The analytical engine behind every investment and M&A; decision. Do this before valuation.

Coursera · Single course

06 [MBA Core: Financial Modeling]

Business and Financial Modeling Specialization

UPenn / Wharton · Profs. Richard Waterman + team · 5-course Specialization · 9.5/10 rated

Quantitative modeling, spreadsheet modeling, scenario analysis, Monte Carlo simulation, optimization (Solver), capstone using Wharton Research Data Services real data.

Coursera · 5-course Specialization

07 [MBA Elective: Valuation]

Financial Modeling & Valuation: Analyze & Forecast

EDUCBA · Single course · Recently updated

Full DCF model build from scratch: revenue forecasting, FCFF, FCFE, WACC, EV/EBITDA multiples, comparable company analysis. Bridges corporate finance theory into analyst-grade practice.

Coursera · Single course

08 [MBA Core: Financial Statement Analysis]

Practical Financial Statement Analysis

Udemy · Inst: Jason Williams (ex–Credit Suisse, Accounting & Tax Research)

10-K reading, quality of earnings, key ratios (ROE, P/E, debt/equity, EV multiples), red flags in financial reporting. Applied complement to the Wharton accounting course.

Udemy · Single course (library card)

Sem 3 Investments & Portfolio Management

Wharton/Columbia MBA Year 1–2 equivalent · Months 8–13 · Prereq: Sem 2 complete

09 [MBA Core: Financial Markets]

Financial Markets

Yale University · Prof. Robert Shiller (Nobel laureate) · Single course · 4.8★ · 33 hrs

Market structure, risk, CAPM, efficient markets, behavioral finance, banking, insurance, investment banking. The broadest single-course view of finance from a Nobel laureate.

Coursera · Single course

10 [MBA Core: Investments & Portfolio Theory]

Investment and Portfolio Management Specialization

Rice University · Prof. Arzu Ozoguz + faculty · 4-course Specialization + capstone · 15 weeks

Mean-variance optimization, factor models, CAPM, active vs passive management, portfolio construction, performance evaluation, behavioral biases in investing.

Coursera · 4-course Specialization

11 [MBA Elective: Investing Practice]

Complete Investing Course 2026 (Stocks, ETFs & Funds)

Udemy · Inst: Calvin K. Lee, CPA/CA/MBA · York University · 74,000+ students

Practical companion to Rice portfolio theory: how to actually open brokerage accounts, buy ETFs, build a personal portfolio, understand mutual funds vs ETFs vs REITs.

Udemy · Single course (library card)

12 [MBA Elective: Behavioral Finance]

Behavioral Finance

Duke University · Profs. Emma Rasiel & John A. Forlines III · Single course

Cognitive biases, loss aversion, herding, overconfidence, market anomalies that standard theory can't explain. Covered in most top MBA programs as an investments elective.

Coursera · Single course

Sem 4 Derivatives, Fixed Income & Risk Management

Wharton / Columbia MBA Year 2 equivalent · Months 13–18 · Prereq: Sem 3 complete

13 [MBA Elective: Derivatives & Risk]

Financial Engineering and Risk Management Specialization

Columbia University · Profs. Martin Haugh, Garud Iyengar + team · 5-course Specialization

Options, futures, swaps, Black-Scholes, binomial trees, delta hedging, fixed income derivatives, MBS, credit derivatives (CDOs, CDS), portfolio optimization, algo trading. Graduate-level rigor.

Coursera · 5-course Specialization

14 [MBA Elective: Real Estate]

Introduction to Real Estate Investing

Alison · Single course (free)

Mortgages, home equity mechanics, REITs, property valuation basics, cap rates. Practical coverage of an asset class most MBA programs address in electives.

Alison · Single course (free)

Sem 5

Advanced Finance — M&A;, FinTech & Quantitative Methods

MBA Year 2 electives + your AI/ML differentiator · Months 18–24 · Syncs with McDaniel AI coursework

15 [MBA Elective: M&A; / Corporate Finance II]

Mergers & Acquisitions — A Comprehensive Overview

Udemy · Inst: Stefan Ljensen (ex-investment banker) · Single course

Deal structures, LBO basics, synergy valuation, due diligence, post-merger integration. Covers the advanced corporate finance topics Wharton places in year 2 electives.

Udemy · Single course (library card)

16 [MBA Elective: FinTech]

Financial Technology (Fintech) Innovations Specialization

University of Michigan · Profs. Robert Dittmar & Andrew Wu · 4-course Specialization · 4.7★ · Coursera Plus

Payment systems, blockchain & crypto, fundraising & crowdfunding, AI in investment/robo-advising. Available on Coursera Plus. Michigan is the replacement for the Wharton FinTech specialization.

Coursera · 4-course Specialization

17 [MBA Elective: ML for Finance]

Machine Learning for Trading Specialization

Google Cloud + NYIF · Inst: Jack Farmer · 3-course Specialization · Intermediate

Trading strategy, ML signal generation, pairs trading, momentum, Keras/TensorFlow models, backtesting. The direct bridge between your AI/ML McDaniel track and quantitative finance.

Coursera · 3-course Specialization

18 [MBA Elective: Python for Finance]

Python for Finance & Algorithmic Trading with QuantConnect

Udemy · Inst: Jose Portilla (Head of Data Science, Pierian Training) · Single course

NumPy, Pandas, yfinance, Matplotlib, QuantConnect/LEAN engine, building and backtesting real trading algorithms in Python. Applied capstone for your entire roadmap.

Udemy · Single course (library card)

Curriculum Summary

Semester	MBA Equivalent	Courses / Specializations	Platform	Est. Duration
Sem 1	Year 1 Block 1 — Foundations	4 single courses	Coursera + Alison	~4 months
Sem 2	Year 1 Block 2 — Corp Finance & Modeling	3 courses + 1 Specialization (5 courses)	Coursera + Udemy	~4 months
Sem 3	Year 1–2 — Investments & Portfolio	2 single courses + 1 Specialization (4) + 1 elective	Coursera + Udemy	~5 months
Sem 4	Year 2 — Derivatives & Risk	1 Specialization (5 courses) + 1 single	Coursera + Alison	~5 months

Sem 5	Year 2 Electives + AI track	2 Specializations (7 courses) + 2 singles	Coursera + Udemy	~6 months
TOTAL	~Wharton/HBS/Columbia Finance MBA	18 courses across 5 specializations	All platforms	18–24 months

Platforms: Coursera (paid subscription / Coursera Plus) · Udemy (NJ library card) · Alison (free) · YouTube/Khan Academy (free)